MASTERING PIE CHARTS · LESSON 1 CHEAT SHEET

Describing Pie Charts

Proportions, the passive and comparisons: the language for describing parts of a whole.

Percentages, fractions and "one in ..."

%	FRACTION	ONE IN ...
5%	a twentieth	one in twenty
10%	a tenth	one in ten
12.5%	an eighth	one in eight
17%	a sixth	one in six
20%	a fifth	one in five
25%	a quarter	one in four
30%	—	three in ten
33%	a third	one in three
40%	two fifths	two in five
50%	a half	one in two
60%	three fifths	three in five
67%	two thirds	two in three
70%	—	seven in ten
75%	three quarters	three in four
80%	four fifths	four in five
90%	—	nine in ten

For 30%, 70% and 90%, *three in ten*, *seven in ten* and *nine in ten* sound more natural than tenths.

Percentage of what?

Every figure is a percentage of the **whole pie**, so check the title.

70% of part-time students were over 25.
70% of students over 25 studied part-time. (turns the chart around)
Part-time students were 48%. (48% of what?)

Only describe what the chart shows: no reasons, no preferences.

When the figure isn't exact

MEANING	WORDS	EXAMPLE
A little more	just over, slightly more than	26%: just over a quarter
A little less	just under, almost, nearly	48%: almost half
Close, either side	about, around, roughly, approximately	34%: roughly a third
Much more / less	well over, considerably less than	60%: well over half

Almost and **nearly** always mean *less*. 52% is almost half → just over half.

Words for proportions

the vast majority, almost all	about 85–99%
a large majority	about 65–85%
the majority, most, more than half	over 50%
a significant minority	about 30–45%
a small minority, a small proportion	about 5–15%
a tiny fraction, very few	under 5%

The majority means more than half, not the biggest slice. A 28% slice is the largest proportion, not the majority.

Grammar and comparisons

Was or were?

The verb agrees with the noun after **of**, not the fraction:

*A third of the students **were** over 25.*
*A third of the waste **was** recycled.*
*One in ten diners **was** vegetarian.*

Uncountable nouns take **was**: waste, money, energy, water.

The passive

Use it when the chart shows what happened *to* something: waste, money, energy, land.

was / were + past participle
Just over a third of household waste was recycled.
Around a quarter was sent to landfill.

34% of waste recycled (no *was*) · was send → **was sent** · past year → **was**, not *is*

Instead of repeating "percentage"

WORD	EXAMPLE	WATCH OUT
account for	*India accounted for 22%.*	needs **for**
make up	*Russia made up 12% of the total.*	not made up of
represent	*Germany represented a tenth.*	no preposition
constitute	*Landfill constituted a quarter.*	formal: use once
share, proportion	*China had the largest share.*	not the most share
per cent	*Twenty-eight per cent of students…*	after a number
percentage	*A high percentage of students…*	never after a number

Seven ways to compare slices

1. **More / fewer** students came from China than from Russia. (fewer for countable nouns)
2. The proportion from China was **higher than** that from India.
3. Nigeria's share was **not as high as** Russia's.
4. China accounted for **the largest** proportion; India for **the second largest**.
5. **As many** students came from Brazil **as** from Germany.
6. Russia's share was **twice** Nigeria's. China's was **almost three times** Germany's.
7. Brazil and Germany accounted for **equal** / **similar** proportions.

Adding the data

- **Brackets:** *…than from Brazil (22% compared with 10%).*
- **Colon:** *…was higher than India's: 28%, compared with 22%.*
- **Whereas / while:** *A fifth came from India, whereas only 6% came from Nigeria.*
- **Specifically:** new sentence. *Specifically, they accounted for 28% and 22% respectively.*

Check before you finish

1. Percentage of what? Is the whole the chart title?
2. Are my fractions precise: just over, just under, almost?
3. Did I use the passive where nobody did the action?
4. Did I compare slices with a range of structures?
5. Did I add figures to support each comparison?